SMS1281 ACADEMIC WRITING

Mid-Term Test

20TH April, 2026

TIME: 16:00 -17:30 HOURS

TIME ALLOWED: **WRITING – ONE HOUR THIRTY MINUTES**

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Answer Any 2 questions
2. This examination paper carries a total of **50 marks.**
3. Candidates must **not turn this page** until the invigilator tells them to do so.

Attempt ANY TWO questions from this section

Question one

A. Case Study

You are the Head of the ICT Directorate at a public university that has recently intensified its use of digital learning platforms, particularly the Learning Management System (LMS) and Microsoft Teams, to support blended and online learning.

Over the past two months, the university has been experiencing persistent internet connectivity challenges characterized by:

- Intermittent network outages and slow internet speeds
- Limited access to the LMS by both staff and students
- Poor visibility and streaming of recorded lectures on Microsoft Teams
- Delays in uploading teaching materials
- Increased student complaints regarding inability to submit continuous assessments on time

These challenges have significantly disrupted teaching, learning, and assessment processes, thereby affecting students' academic progress and overall learning experience. In response, the university management, through the ICT Directorate, has initiated several mitigation measures, including:

- Upgrading internet bandwidth through engagement with a new service provider
- Installing additional Wi-Fi access points across campus
- Optimizing LMS and Microsoft Teams performance
- Providing technical support to staff and students
- Encouraging flexible deadlines and alternative modes of content delivery

Despite these efforts, concerns persist among academic staff and students, and the situation requires clear communication and guidance from your office.

Task:

B. Write a formal internal memo to inform everyone (20 Marks)

C. Enumerate 5 advantages and 5 disadvantages of written communication (5 marks)

(Total 25 Marks)

Question 2

Write structured notes on "Note-Taking Methods in Academic Writing" using the Outline Method. Your answer must demonstrate: Main points, Specific points, and more specific points showing further details using proper indentation.

A. Outline Method 5 marks

B. Cornell Method 5 marks

C. Mapping (Mind Map) Method 5 marks

D. Charting Method 5 marks

E. Sentence Method 5 Marks

(Total 25 marks)

Question 3

You are the Communications Manager for a large public university in Zambia that recently entered into a formal partnership with the international technology firm TechNova Global Solutions Ltd to implement a digital learning system across all faculties. However, since the rollout of the system, the university has experienced several critical challenges, including:

- Frequent system downtime affecting teaching, learning, and administrative operations
- Data synchronization errors resulting in partial loss of student academic records
- Delays and inefficiencies in technical support from the partner organization
- Increasing complaints from students and staff
- Growing reputational concerns raised by regulatory bodies and the media

Despite multiple internal engagements and informal communications with the partner organization, the issues remain unresolved. University Management has now directed that a **formal external communication** be issued to address the matter at the highest level.

Task:

A. As a communications manager, write a formal business letter toTechNova Global Solutions Ltd addressed to:

The Chief Executive Officer
TechNova Global Solutions Ltd
Plot 1207, Cairo Drive
P.O. Box 34567
Lusaka, Zambia **(15 Marks)**

B. Identify and explain 10 mistakes to avoid when writing a job application letter (10 marks)

(Total 25 Marks)

END OF TEST